

ROUTLEDGE FOCUS

COOL BRITANNIA AND MULTI-ETHNIC BRITAIN

Uncorking the Champagne Supernova

Jason Arday

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Focus



Cool Britannia and Multi-Ethnic Britain

Cool Britannia and Multi-Ethnic Britain: Uncorking the Champagne Supernova attempts to move away from the melancholia of Cool Britannia and the discourse which often encases the period by repositioning this phenomenon through an ethnic minority perspective.

In March 1997, the front page of the magazine *Vanity Fair* announced 'London Swings! Again!' This headline was a direct reference to the swinging London of the 1960s – the English capital which became the era-defining epicentre of the world for its burgeoning rock and pop music scene, with its daring new youth culture, and the boutique fashion houses of Carnaby Street captured most indelibly by the Mods, Rockers, and psychedelic hippies of the time. In the 1990s this renewed interest in the swinging 60s seemed to reinvigorate popular culture, after a global period in the 1980s which would see the collapse of traditional communism and the ending of Cold War, while ushering in the beginnings of a new technological age spearheaded by Apple, Microsoft, and IBM. The dawn of the 1990s meant that peace and love would once again reign supreme, with Britannia being at the forefront of 'cool' again. Godfathers of the Mancunian Rock scene New Order would declare 'Love had the world in motion' and, for a fleeting period, Britain was about to encounter its second coming as the cultural epicentre of the world.

Although history proffers a period of utopia, inclusion, and cultural integration, the narrative alters considerably when exploring this euphoric period through a discriminatory and racialised lens. This book repositions the ethnic minority-lived experience during the 1990s from the societal and political margins to the centre. The lexicon explored attempts to provide an altogether different discourse that allows us to reflect on seminal and racially discriminatory episodes during the 1990s that subsequently illuminated the systemic racism sustained by the state. The Cool Britannia years become a metaphoric reference point for presenting a Britain that was culturally splintered in many ways. This book utilises storytelling and auto-ethnography as an instrument to unpack the historical amnesia that ensues when unpacking the racialised plights of the time.

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Jason Arday

First published 2020

by Routledge

2 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon OX14 4RN

and by Routledge

52 Vanderbilt Avenue, New York, NY 10017

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

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British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Names: Arday, Jason, author.

Title: Cool Britannia and multi-ethnic Britain : uncorking the champagne supernova / Jason Arday.

Description: Abingdon, Oxon ; New York, NY : Routledge, 2020. | Includes bibliographical references and index.

Identifiers: LCCN 2019034556 (print) | LCCN 2019034557 (ebook) | ISBN 9781138217409 (hardback) | ISBN 9781315440644 (ebook)

Subjects: LCSH: Minorities—Great Britain—Social conditions. | Great Britain—Ethnic relations—History—20th century. | Great Britain—Race relations—History—20th century.

Classification: LCC DA125.A1 A855 2020 (print) |

LCC DA125.A1 (ebook) | DDC 305.800941—dc23

LC record available at <https://lcn.loc.gov/2019034556>

LC ebook record available at <https://lcn.loc.gov/2019034557>

ISBN: 978-1-138-21740-9 (hbk)

ISBN: 978-1-315-44064-4 (ebk)

Typeset in Times New Roman

by Apex CoVantage, LLC

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Acknowledgements

It was my dream to write a book on a period that would ultimately define my life and that of countless others in many ways. The Cool Britannia years provided a soundtrack to my life that still reverberates in my ears today and that reverberation has made it possible to write this book.

I would like to thank the following colleagues and friends who have been instrumental in supporting me throughout this process: Heidi Mirza, Vikki Boliver, Michael Cobden, Melissa Clarke, Dave Thomas, Suhraiya Jivraj, Paul Warmington, Robbie Shilliam, Paulette Williams, Chantelle Lewis, Remi Joseph-Salisbury, Vini Lander, Dominik Jackson-Cole, Tamanda Walker, Marcia Wilson, Anthony Maher, Michael Hobson, Shirin Housee, Leah Bassel, Paul Miller, Shirley-Anne Tate, Delayna Spencer, Beth Thomas-Hancock, and Dina Belluigi. I also wish to thank the Routledge Editorial Team – Elena Chiu, Emily Briggs, Chris Mathews, and Lakshita Joshi – for their continued help. They have been unstinting in their support and patience on this important project.

I would like to extend a huge thanks to my exceptional family: Debbie-Ann, Taylah, Noah, Mum, Dad, Simon, and Joseph. As always, I would also like to extend my appreciation and gratitude to Sandro Sandri; without him . . . the dream would not be possible.

To all the participants that participated in the initial early phase of this project some years ago: thank you so much for your stories of navigating racism throughout the 90s as an ethnic minority in

Britain. I only hope that I have been able to do your stories justice. This book would never have come to fruition if not for all of you; I am eternally grateful.

This book is dedicated to the enduring memory of Stephen Lawrence and his parents, Doreen and Neville, who have been unrelenting in their pursuit for racial equality in Britain. We all owe your family a significant debt of gratitude.

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I am he as you are (s)he as you are me . . . and we are all together.
(‘I Am the Walrus’, The Beatles, 1967)